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The Ramah Story: Magic of Jewish Summer Camp

January 15, 2026 | Jewish Journal of Greater Los Angeles, The (CA)
Author: Ryan Torok | Section: Community | 1367 Words
OpenURL Link

It's well known that Jewish summer camps of all denominations have been instrumental in nurturing Jewish identity for new generations of American Jewry. Here in Los Angeles, one of the leading lights of that movement has been Camp Ramah.

Late last year, the Ramah story was celebrated in a glitzy gala at Sinai Temple, which drew some 500 attendees.

The event honored Janine Winkler Lowy, a longtime supporter of the camp, and her children, Simonette, Jacqueline, Benjamin and Caroline; and also recognized State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) along with his brother, Oren, both of whom are Ramahniks (the term used for former campers).

To convey its strong support for Israel, the gala also featured Talia Bodner and Bali Lavine, two 2025 Ramah staff members who spoke about how camp helped them become pro-Israel advocates on their college campuses. For a large group of dedicated Jewish community members still reeling from the aftermath of Oct. 7, 2023, hearing a pair of young leaders speak about their strong connections to Israel — and attributing their pro-Israel identities to summer camp — affirmed what many already knew: Jewish summer camp works.

But what is it about Camp Ramah, located in the rural mountains of Ojai, California, that builds such strong feelings of Jewish pride, nurtures lifelong connections to the camp and inculcates a proud Zionism in young people? Camp Ramah in California CEO Joe Menashe attributed it to the unique summer camp magic.

"I went to a Jewish summer camp when I was 9, 10, and 11, Camp Solomon Schechter, outside of Seattle, Washington — I grew up in the Pacific Northwest — and it is hard for me to imagine that I would be here today as a rabbi, as a community leader, as devoting my entire life's professional purpose to serving our Jewish community without having had even just those three years as a little kid," Menashe told The Journal.

"I happen to have fallen in love with Ramah," he said. "I think Ramah is a special and unique community educational institution, and so much more. And we're not the only great flavor of Jewish summer camping that's out there."

Camp Ramah in California, founded in 1956, is one of the Southern California region's largest Jewish sleep-away summer camps, enrolling several hundred campers each summer. Affiliated with the Conservative movement — it's been called "A jewel in the crown of Conservative Judaism" — and the National Ramah Commission, which oversees 10 residential camps throughout the U.S., Canada and Israel, it offers a residential camp, a day camp and year-round programming. Prominent alumni include actor and singer Ben Platt and author Chaim Potok ("The Chosen"), who served as director of the camp in the late 1950s before embarking on a career as a writer.

Despite the camp's affiliation with the Conservative movement, the Southern California camp's CEO suggested a camp's denominational affiliation doesn't matter much nowadays when families are looking for a place for their kid's summer.

"I think in current times, denominationalism is not as much of an interest to families as [it is] a marketing tool," Menashe said.

But of interest, most of all, are the people one is surrounded by at camp. There's an unofficial "I met my spouse at Ramah" club. More formally, the Ojai camp's "Gesher L'Chuppah" provides married couples who met at camp the opportunity to support Ramah by purchasing plaques with their names. Among the names is Rabbi Menashe, who

met his wife at Ramah in the 1990s. Another is Rabbi Tova Leibovic-Douglas, who was ordained at American Jewish University's Ziegler School of Rabbinic Studies and serves the LA community as a spiritual counselor and educator.

Some are a lucky enough to meet their bashert (soulmate). Others come and find their lifelong friends. Menashe recalled a Ramah madricha (counselor) who offered Menashe and his wife what the Ramah CEO called "a bit of a loving Torah, a loving kind of a subtle correction."

"'I might meet my bashert at camp, I might not, but I don't come to camp to meet my bashert,'" Menashe recalled the counselor saying. "'I come to camp to meet my bridesmaids.'" For the Ramah leader, it was an "aha!" moment, one that underlined the "stickiness of life of Jewish summer camp."

In addition to Jewish rituals, throw in rope swings, color wars, bunk bonding, Shabbat evenings under the stars — and even mud hugs — and you have a recipe for a memorable summer.

Mud hugs? "We have something called 'mud hugs,' where our oldest campers, after a five-day camping trip, do an eight-and-a-half-mile hike back to camp, and then run into camp covered head-to-toe in mud," Menashe explained. "It's a special tradition that kids look forward to."

The camp is also proudly Zionist. More than 30 Israeli counselors work at the camp every summer. Each of the last two summers, the camp has accommodated more than 80 families from Israel. As the recent gala demonstrated, there's "big tent Zionist" community at Ramah.

"As we look on college campuses today, those that are stepping forward to be the student leaders in Israel groups and Hillels and Chabads, first and foremost, they're Jewish camp kids, and among them, so many of them, disproportionately, are Ramahniks," he said.

Are there any viewpoints on Israel that fall outside of the 'big tent'? "So, there are certainly edges on the left and edges on the right that we would say don't fall into the pale of our educational sphere. And what we teach eight-year-olds about Zionism and Israel is going to be different than what we teach 15-year-olds or what our counselors are talking about at night," Menashe said. "But we are deeply connected to Israel."

When she was eight years old, Rita Weiss attended her first summer at Ramah. Her father paid a monthly $250 to send his only daughter on scholarship there. Ramah became a second home for her. She started as a camper, became a CIT and eventually became a counselor. She was in the first group to experience camp on its current grounds in Ojai.

The friendships she made at camp have lasted a lifetime, and she credits Ramah with inspiring her to travel to Israel during her junior year of college.

Her camp memories are vivid: She recalled peanut butter sandwiches on Tisha b'Av when it became too difficult to fast the entire day; watching the 1969 moon landing on a TV wheeled into the camp dining hall; and listening to late Holocaust survivor Emil Jacoby, who served as director of education at Ramah.

To this day, she still remembers the Hebrew lyrics from the camp's musicals. And whenever she hears morning blessings, she smells cornflakes—the breakfast served at camp following morning services.

"I lived for camp," Weiss said. "It was 'living Judaism.' Camp made it easy to practice Judaism because it was all right there. For those weeks or months at camp, it was just your life."

This ruach (spirit) continues at Ramah each summer. A new group of kids pack duffel bags or foot lockers, say goodbye to their parents and the noise of the city life and venture off to a remote, rustic, recreation-filled setting, where they play, pray and socialize outdoors, sleep in bunks and are exposed to the unique magic of camp.

It's a formula, Menashe told The Journal, for building future Jewish leaders who have positive associations with

Jewish experiences. Because camp experiences, whether corn flakes or mud hugs, can't be found in any other Jewish setting.

Among the brightest and proudest Jewels at Ramah are the Tikvah programs, which provide opportunities for young adults with special needs to experience the magic of the camp. The program is designed to support campers and staff members of all abilities, creating support systems, modified schedules and programs to ensure that everyone's needs are being met thoughtfully.

"We're not the only great flavor of Jewish summer camping that's out there," Menashe said. "I'm a big believer in Jewish summer camp, and the Jewish community is served by having more beds — more types of opportunities — for Jewish expression and connection to community.

"From the secular Zionist to the community camps to the Reform, the Young Judea, the Conservative, which is Ramah, to the modern Orthodox to the Haredi, the Jewish community, long term, benefits from all of them."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Torok, R. (2026, January 15). The Ramah Story: Magic of Jewish Summer Camp. *Jewish Journal of Greater Los Angeles, The (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A5A5617CE59FB10.